

Week-5 Essay

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Introduction

The chapter 7 of "*Weapons of Math Destruction*" delves into how data-driven scheduling practices have transformed the lives of low-wage workers in the retail and service industries. This chapter emphasizes how these practices harm workers' well-being and disrupt family life, showing that data-driven models often value efficiency and profit above human needs. The chapter 5 of "*Everybody Lies*" discusses the potential of Big Data to revolutionize healthcare by providing insights that were previously unattainable. However, it identifies the challenges in data collection and integration as significant barriers to realizing these benefits.

Literature Review

In Chapter 5 of *Everybody Lies*, Seth Stephens-Davidowitz this chapter begins with the context of teacher evaluations in the United States, tracing back to the 1983 report "A Nation at Risk," which criticized American education and pushed for standardized testing. The chapter begins with the context of teacher evaluations in the United States, tracing back to the 1983 report "A Nation at Risk," which criticized American education and pushed for standardized testing. This model aims to assess a teacher's effectiveness based on student test scores, leading to arbitrary and often unjust outcomes. The story of Tim Clifford, a middle school teacher whose evaluation scores varied dramatically year to year without changes in his teaching methods, exemplifies this issue. The variability in scores reflects the randomness and inaccuracy of the model. The chapter criticizes the model's reliance on statistical approximations, which introduce significant noise and unreliability. VAM attempts to adjust for social inequalities by comparing students to predicted scores, but this approach results in guesses on top of guesses, leading to random and unfair evaluations.

In Chapter 7 of *Weapons of Math Destruction*, Cathy O'Neil introduces "clopening," a scheduling practice where employees work late to close a store and return early to open it, leading to chaotic and exhausting work schedules. The chapter discusses how irregular and unpredictable work schedules have become common in major corporations like Starbucks, McDonald's, and Walmart. The chapter highlights the case of Jannette Navarro, a single mother whose chaotic schedule at Starbucks made it nearly impossible to balance work, childcare, and education. The chapter traces the origins of such scheduling practices to the field of operations research (OR), which emphasizes efficiency. However, the application of OR models to human scheduling often disregards workers' personal lives and well-being.

Analysis of the Issue

In "*Everybody Lies*," the chapter traces the origins of such scheduling practices to the field of operations research (OR), which gained prominence during World War II. OR and its emphasis on efficiency have since infiltrated corporate practices, leading to the adoption of "just-in-time" supply chains and scheduling software. While these models have proven efficient in manufacturing and logistics, their application to human scheduling often disregards the personal lives and well-being of workers. In "*Weapons of Math Destruction*," chapter highlights the negative impact of such practices on workers' well-being and family lives, illustrating how data-driven models prioritize efficiency and profits over human needs.

Conclusion and Limitations

The chapter 7 of Weapons of Math Destruction concludes by emphasizing the need for fairer and more accurate methods of teacher evaluation. It highlights the importance of recognizing the statistical flaws in value-added models to ensure justice for educators. In the chapter 5 of Everybody Lies concludes by calling for societal intervention to counteract the negative effects of data-driven scheduling models. It argues for press coverage, regulatory action, and strong unions to address these issues. Ultimately, the chapter emphasizes the need for a balance between efficiency and justice in corporate practices, highlighting the importance of prioritizing human needs alongside economic goals.

References

- Davidowitz, S. S. (2017). *Everybody lies: Big data, new data, and what the internet can tell us about who we really are*. Dey Street Books.
- O'Neil, C. (2016). In *Weapons of math destruction: how big data increases inequality and threatens democracy*. Crown Publishers.